

V3 Structured Feedback Exchange

Formerly: Feedback Roulette. Rebuilt from scratch. The original anonymous bowl mechanic created anxiety without support. This version provides psychological safety through structure.

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 3
Time Required	50-60 minutes	Group Size	4-8 (optimal: 6)
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person preferred
Prerequisites	V1 (Vulnerability Circle) strongly recommended	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Low feedback culture scores, difficulty giving/receiving feedback, avoidance of constructive criticism

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Receiving feedback activates the brain's threat detection system. The amygdala scans incoming feedback for social danger: Am I being judged? Is my status at risk? Will this affect my standing in the group? When feedback arrives without warning, without context, or without safety, cortisol spikes and the prefrontal cortex (rational thinking) goes offline. The person hears the threat, not the content.

Structured feedback reverses this. When the recipient knows what to expect, has time to prepare, and feels in control of the process, the prefrontal cortex stays engaged. The brain can process the feedback as information rather than threat. Adding positive feedback alongside constructive feedback activates dopamine reward circuits, making the whole experience feel more balanced.

The original Feedback Roulette format (anonymous notes in a bowl, random distribution) maximised threat signals: no control, no context, no relationship. This rebuilt version prioritises the relationship between giver and receiver.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"Most of us have never been taught how to give or receive feedback in a way that actually lands. We either avoid it entirely or deliver it badly. This exercise lets us practise both in a structured, safe way so that feedback becomes a normal part of how we work together, not something we dread."

Before You Begin

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY CHECK

This is a Level 3 exercise. Do NOT run it if:

- The team has not completed V1 or equivalent trust-building work
- There are unresolved interpersonal conflicts that could hijack the feedback process
- The team has a history of feedback being used punitively (in performance reviews, in public settings)
- Anyone on the team is in a probation period or performance management process

If any of these conditions exist, start with V8 (Balancing Vulnerability) and C15 (Feedback Culture) first.

Pre-work (sent 48 hours before the session)

Send each team member a simple brief: "In our next session, each person will give one piece of feedback to one other person, and receive one piece of feedback from someone else. You'll know who you're giving to, and you'll have time to prepare. The feedback should be work-related, specific, and constructive. Think about what would genuinely help the other person."

Assign feedback pairs. Every person gives to one person and receives from a different person. The manager participates as both giver and receiver. Pairings should be rotated if you run this exercise again.

The Exercise

Phase 1: Framing and Ground Rules (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Today we're practising feedback as a skill. Not performance review feedback. Not criticism. Feedback as something we do for each other because we want each other to succeed."

"Ground rules: the feedback you give should be specific, about work behaviour (not personality), and aimed at helping. The person receiving feedback listens fully, then responds with what they heard, not with a defence. We'll practise this structure together."

Phase 2: Feedback Structure Teaching (5 minutes)

Introduce the SBI framework on the flipchart/screen:

- Situation: "In last week's project review meeting..."
- Behaviour: "...you presented the data without context for the new team members..."
- Impact: "...which meant they couldn't contribute to the discussion and two important questions went unasked."

Demonstrate with a live example. Give feedback to yourself, out loud, using SBI: "In yesterday's planning session, I moved through the agenda too quickly without checking whether people had questions. The impact was that two decisions got made without full input."

Phase 3: Preparation (5 minutes)

Each person prepares their feedback using SBI. They write it down. Writing forces precision and reduces the chance of the feedback becoming vague or emotional in delivery.

Phase 4: Feedback Exchange (25-30 minutes)

Each pair takes turns. The room stays together (no breakout rooms). This matters: the group witnessing feedback being given and received well normalises the practice.

Sequence for each exchange (3-4 minutes per pair):

9. Giver delivers feedback using SBI structure.
10. Receiver pauses. Counts to three silently. Then responds: "What I heard was..." (reflects back without defending).
11. Giver confirms or clarifies: "Yes, that's it" or "Not quite, what I meant was..."
12. Receiver says: "Thank you. I'll think about that." Full stop. No explanation, no justification, no counter-feedback.

FACILITATION NOTE

The hardest part for receivers is not defending. Coach this explicitly: "Your job right now is to hear it, not to respond to it. You'll have time to process later. For now, just listen and reflect back."

If a receiver starts defending, intervene gently: "Can I pause you there? Try just reflecting back what you heard first."

Phase 5: Debrief (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"We're not going to discuss the content of anyone's feedback. That's private between each pair. What I want to explore is the process. What was harder: giving or receiving? What was it like to reflect back without defending? What surprised you?"

Let the debrief run naturally. The insights that emerge here are the real learning: people consistently report that receiving feedback is harder than giving it, and that the reflection step changed how they processed the content.

Phase 6: Close (3 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"This was a structured exercise. Real feedback doesn't happen in a session like this. It happens in the moment, in the work. My ask is this: between now and our next team meeting, find one opportunity to give someone on this team a piece of feedback using the structure we practised. It doesn't have to be big. It just has to be real."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Feedback becomes personal rather than behavioural ("You're always disorganised")	Intervene immediately but gently: "Can I help reframe that? Let's get specific. What's a recent situation where this showed up?" Guide them back to SBI. If the receiver is visibly hurt, acknowledge it: "That landed differently than intended. Let's reset and try again with a specific example."
A receiver becomes defensive or argumentative	Redirect: "I can see this is landing. Let's come back to the structure. Right now, your only job is to reflect back what you heard." If they cannot, offer a break: "Take a moment. We can come back to this." Do NOT force the exchange to continue if the safety has been compromised.
The feedback is too vague to be useful ("You're doing great, keep it up")	Coach in real time: "That's a good starting point. Can you make it more specific? What's one thing they did recently that you want to see more of?" This teaches specificity without embarrassing the giver.
Someone's feedback reveals a serious unresolved issue between them and the receiver	Do not let it play out in the group. Acknowledge: "This sounds like something that needs a deeper conversation. Can the two of you set aside time this week to talk it through? I'm happy to facilitate if that would help." Follow up to ensure the conversation happens.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Receivers genuinely listen rather than preparing their rebuttal At least one person says "I didn't know that's how it landed" The debrief generates honest reflection about the difficulty of feedback
Within 1-2 weeks	Someone gives unsolicited feedback using the SBI structure outside of the exercise A team member asks for feedback rather than waiting to receive it Feedback references become normal rather than loaded ("Can I give you some quick feedback on that?")
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Vulnerability scores increase Communication scores improve (feedback is a communication accelerator) Qualitative responses reference openness, honesty, or trust
Red flags	If people avoid each other after the session or become more guarded, the exercise may have surfaced content that was not adequately contained. Follow up individually.

Remote/Hybrid Adaptation

Element	Remote Modification
Exchange format	Keep the full group on video. Do NOT use breakout rooms. The group witnessing the exchanges is part of the normalisation.
Preparation	Use a private document or notebook. Never write feedback in shared digital spaces.
Nonverbal cues	Ask receivers to nod or give a visible acknowledgment when they hear the feedback. Online, the giver cannot see body language as clearly and may interpret silence as rejection.
Timing	Allow 4-5 minutes per pair instead of 3-4. The reflection-back step takes longer online without physical proximity cues.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	V1 builds the trust that makes V3 possible. Without trust, feedback exchange becomes performative.	Run V1 before V3 (2+ weeks gap)
C15: Feedback Culture	C15 addresses the systemic conditions for feedback. V3 provides the practice. They work as a pair.	Run C15 before or alongside V3
V8: Balancing Vulnerability	If V3 is too intense for the team, V8 is a gentler entry point.	Alternative entry if V1 has not been completed
L6: Accountability in Learning	Feedback is a key input for learning accountability. V3 establishes the skill.	Complementary